

TEAM 2 · Take Tenuta Corte Aurelia into the USA

Wine Business Program 2026 · **Generative AI Workshop** Tool for today: **Microsoft 365 Copilot Chat** at <https://m365.cloud.microsoft/chat>

This handout is self-contained. The company, the CEO's brief, your market and *your* cost line are all in here. Everything else you need is in the `case_study_helper_info` folder next to this file: the Prompting Guide (read it before you start), the rescue guide, and the indicative deck.

1. The company

Tenuta Corte Aurelia is a family-owned **Chianti Classico DOCG** estate in **Greve in Chianti, Tuscany**, in the heart of the Gallo Nero zone.

Founded	1952 · third generation · family-owned
Run by	Elena Aurelia (CEO, commercial) and Marco Aurelia (winemaker)
Estate	45 ha total · 28 ha under vine (250–420 m, galestro and alberese soils)
Certifications	Certified sustainable (Equalitas) · final year of organic conversion
Grapes	Sangiovese 90% · Canaiolo · Colorino
Production	~180,000 bottles per year

The portfolio

Wine	Type	Volume	Ex-cellar price
Corte Aurelia	Chianti Classico Annata DOCG	~90,000 btl	€7.50
Vigna del Sasso	Chianti Classico Riserva DOCG	~40,000 btl	€12.00
Aurelia	Chianti Classico Gran Selezione DOCG	~15,000 btl	€20.00
Rosato Toscana IGP · Sangiovese/Merlot IGT	Entry / experimental	~35,000 btl	Italy only

Story assets: 70+ years of family heritage · restored 16th-century farmhouse · 8-room agriturismo · ~4,000 wine-tourism visitors per year · hand-harvest · native yeasts on the top wines · organic conversion.

Current sales mix (by volume): Italy 55% (HoReCa and enoteche) · Europe 30% (Switzerland, Austria, Benelux) · Rest of world 15% (one-off containers to the US and Asia through traders, with no ongoing importer).

The situation: domestic growth has plateaued. The family has decided to invest in **one priority export market** and build it properly, rather than scattering samples everywhere. Corte Aurelia has no market-specific packaging, no localized marketing, no in-market PR and no critic ratings in that market.

2. A letter from the CEO

To the export task force,

We have money set aside for one market. Not three, one. I have given you €120,000 for the first year: travel, samples, a trade fair, adapted materials, importer support, launch activity.

*Pick the right wine, the right channel and the right story for the market you have been given, and convince me. I want to know three things. **What we would earn. What it really costs me to get there. And how I would know, within twelve months, whether it is actually working**, because by then it will be too late to guess.*

Do not bring me a spreadsheet. Bring me a decision I can sign off, and be honest about what you assumed.

One more thing. We are not discounting our way into anybody's market. Whatever you propose, the premium holds.

Elena

Your market is the USA. One market per team. You own it.

About the market pack. The market briefing in section 3 was put together by our intern over the last few months as an internal research exercise. Treat it as a **starting point**, not as the final word: it is there to save you from a blank page. Elena is explicitly open to further information the task force can find on its own, as long as you say where it came from and flag anything in the pack you end up disagreeing with.

How you get there is up to you. What you hand in is in section 5.

3. Your market: USA

Why the USA. The largest wine-import market by value, and "Chianti" already has enormous name recognition. The problem is that the recognition is **cheap**. Your real challenge is to premiumize and escape the straw-bottle cliché.

How the market works

- **Mandatory three-tier system:** importer → distributor → retailer or on-trade. You appoint an importer, then distributors state by state.
- Sensible start states: **NY, IL, CA, FL, TX.**
- Premium **on-trade** (Italian fine dining, steakhouses, sommelier-driven lists) is the beachhead.
- **Direct-to-consumer shipping is legally restricted.** Do not build the plan on it.

The consumer

- Large **Italian-American** base. Authenticity, estate story and sustainability all sell.
- **Ratings culture is decisive.** A 90+ score from Wine Spectator, James Suckling or Vinous changes the conversation.
- Heavy price compression from big Chianti brands at the value end.

Constraints

- TTB **COLA** label approval plus the Surgeon-General warning. The importer handles this.
- **Tariff status on EU wine is uncertain** and has changed several times since 2025. The Data Pack asks you to model both 0% and 15%. Tell Elena which one you used as your base case and why, and verify the current status before you present either as fact.

3.1 Three questions the USA forces you to answer

Not hints, just the questions your pitch has to survive. Answer them with numbers from section 4.

1. The three-tier system stacks importer **and** distributor margin before retail. **What does that do to your shelf price**, and who are you standing next to once it lands there?
2. "Chianti" is famous *and* cheap in the US. **Which of the three wines actually escapes the cliché**, and can the stock available in section 4.2 supply it at the board's volume?
3. The tariff could be 0% or 15%, and nobody can promise which. **Does your plan still clear €120,000 under both**, and at what point in the year would you know which one you are living with?

4. The Data Pack

These are Corte Aurelia's internal planning figures, agreed with the CFO. **Use these numbers.** Do not ask Copilot to look up different ones, and do not let it invent its own. If you need a figure that is not here, assume it, write the assumption down, and say so in your pitch.

4.1 What a bottle costs us to make

Wine	Ex-cellar price	Variable cost per bottle	Contribution per bottle
Annata	€7.50	€4.20	€3.30
Riserva	€12.00	€6.30	€5.70
Gran Selezione	€20.00	€9.50	€10.50

Variable cost covers grapes, vinification, ageing, bottle, cork, label and case. It excludes estate overheads, which are already carried by the domestic business.

4.2 Extra cost of selling into an export market

Item	Figure
Export compliance and market-specific labelling	€0.15 per bottle
Year-1 market-entry budget (fixed, one-off)	€120,000
Case size	12 bottles

Stock available for the new market in Year 1. The volumes below are uncommitted and available for this initiative. They are included in the estate's planned annual production figures in section 1, not additional production.

Existing customer commitments are protected. For this exercise, assume this allocation has no alternative sales opportunity in Year 1: export sales do not replace domestic sales.

Wine	Available in Year 1
Annata	30,000 btl
Riserva	12,000 btl
Gran Selezione	4,000 btl

These are hard supply ceilings, not sales forecasts. We earn contribution only on bottles the importer actually buys, and an importer buys only what it believes it can sell at full price. Management's expectation of Year-1 demand is set out in section 4.6. Whether your market can really absorb that volume, and in which wines, is your assumption to make and defend. Bottles not purchased by the importer remain in the estate's inventory and generate no Year-1 sales contribution.

The financial measure: Year-1 market result = $\Sigma(\text{bottles sold} \times \text{contribution per bottle}) - €120,000$. Contribution per bottle is ex-cellar price minus variable cost minus the €0.15 export cost. "Net result" in the supporting materials means this same measure.

This is the market's contribution after launch spending, not total estate profit or cash flow. Existing estate overheads, inventory financing and the future value of unsold stock are outside the exercise. Production costs remain in the contribution calculation: uncommitted stock does not mean free wine.

4.3 Your market's price-ladder inputs: USA

Figures are per bottle unless stated. **None of these is the estate's cost.** Under our terms the importer pays freight, duty and excise and passes them down the chain, so they do not reduce your contribution per bottle. They decide the shelf price.

Item	USA
Freight & insurance	€0.45
Import duty	Uncertain: model both 0% and 15%
Excise / alcohol tax	€0.20
Consumer sales tax	varies by state — ignore

Import duty percentages apply to the landed value, meaning ex-cellar price plus freight. State sales tax is ignored.

4.4 The trade chain (same in every market)

Step	Mark-up on their own cost
Importer	+30%
Distributor	+25%
Retail, off-trade	+40%
Restaurant, on-trade	3x the price they pay

4.5 Exchange rate

EUR/USD 1.08

4.6 The board's stated ambition

One quality importer appointed · **25,000 bottles sold in Year 1** · 60,000 by Year 3 · premium positioning protected.

The 25,000 bottles is management's view of what the market could absorb in Year 1, not a stock figure. These are Elena's targets, not facts. If your analysis says they are wrong for the USA, say so and show her why.

5. What you hand in

1. A PowerPoint deck that contains your analysis. Built with **Copilot Chat using Think Deeper (GPT-5.6)**. Maximum **10 slides**. Download it as a .pptx. The PowerPoint should be built on top of your final analysis.

2. One generated image. A **positioning visual for the USA**: the single image you would put in front of a local importer, buyer or consumer to win the business. Label concept, campaign visual, gift pack, tasting-event key visual, your choice. It has to work in *the USA*, not in Tuscany. Put it in the deck.

3. A 5-minute pitch to Elena and the board (the class and the professor), then a **2-minute reflection** on working with the AI: what prompt worked, what it got wrong, what you would never trust it with.

6. Two rules

1. **Show your assumptions.** Every number you invented gets stated out loud.
 2. **Be creative, and have fun with it.** This is a real decision with a real budget, but nobody is going to lose their job over it. Take a position, make it interesting, and enjoy the argument.
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7. Suggested time box

~45 min	Understand the market, build the analysis, stress-test it
~45 min	Generate the image, build the deck
~30 min	Rehearse and sharpen the pitch

Checkpoint at 15 minutes: every team tells the room, in one sentence, **which wine they are leading with and through which channel**. If you cannot say it in one sentence, you are not ready to build yet.

8. Working with Copilot

Two supporting guides sit in the `case_study_helper_info` folder next to this file. Read the first before you start.

- `case_study_helper_info/01_Prompting-Guide.md` — how to set up the session, how to write a prompt that works, and starter prompts for each hand-in. It is there to give you a **head start**, not a script: the starter prompts are yours to lift, adapt or ignore. **You have full freedom in what you submit and how you get there** — the guide just saves you the blank page.
- `case_study_helper_info/02_If-You-Get-Stuck.md` — open it if you stall, or if the numbers will not reconcile. A five-question method for getting to a decision, plus the three core calculations — contribution, the price ladder, the Year-1 total — written out step by step.

Setting up the session: upload *this handout* to Copilot Chat. It contains the brief and the USA market pack in one file, so one upload is enough. Wherever the Prompting Guide says "[YOUR MARKET]", write **the USA**. Wherever it says "*your Market Card*", it means **section 3 of this handout**.

9. Final deliverables

Section 5 says *what* to hand in. This section says what "finished" looks like, so you can check yourselves before you stand up.

9.1 The submission checklist

#	Deliverable	Format	Done when...
1	Board deck, analysis included	<code>.pptx</code> , maximum 10 slides , built with Copilot Chat Think Deeper	It answers Elena's three questions (what we earn, what it costs, how she knows it is working), carries both financial and non-financial indicators , states every assumption you invented, opens cleanly, and sells the decision even without you talking over it

#	Deliverable	Format	Done when...
2	Positioning visual	One generated image (.png / .jpg), placed in the deck	It would work in front of an importer, buyer or consumer in the USA , not in Tuscany
3	Pitch + reflection	5 minutes + 2 minutes, live	Rehearsed and timed, and the reflection names a prompt that worked, something the AI got wrong, and something you would never trust it with

Non-negotiable in all three: the premium holds, every invented number is flagged as an assumption, and all economics trace back to the Data Pack in section 4.

9.2 What Elena expects to see

Five things have to be in your deck. If a slide does not eventually lead to one of them, cut the slide.

1. **Which wine or wines, through which channel** — one sentence, no hedging.
2. **Contribution per bottle** for each wine you lead with: ex-cellar price minus variable cost minus the €0.15 export cost. It is the same in every market, because the importer pays freight and taxes.
3. **Year-1 volume, total contribution, and the Year-1 market result after the €120,000 launch spending**, as defined in section 4.2.
4. **Break-even volume**, and how much margin for error that leaves you.
5. **A strategy pack with your recommendations for the USA.** The moves you would make, in priority order: route to market and the partner you want, pricing and positioning, the story you lead with, the launch activity, and how the €120,000 is split between them. For each one, say why it fits the USA and what Elena has to decide. Close with a clear call: **go, go with conditions, or not yet**, and the conditions.

9.3 Indicative 8-slide deck structure

A shape that works. Not a rule. Adapt it to the US story.

Slide	Working title	What it has to do
1	The recommendation	Market, wine, channel, and three headline numbers (volume, ROI, break-even). The whole answer, up front
2	The obvious plan, and why we rejected it	Show the tempting option and let the numbers kill it. This is where you earn credibility
3	What the market pays for a bottle	The price ladder: ex-cellar → freight → duty and excise → importer → distributor → retail. Finish on the shelf price in USD
4	The Year-1 plan	Wine × volume × channel × contribution, with totals and the net against €120,000
5	Scenarios	Downside, base, upside, each at 0% and 15% tariff . Say what breaks in the downside and what actually limits the upside
6	How Elena will know it is working	Your indicators, with targets, review rhythm, and the action if each one misses
7	The positioning visual	Your generated image, plus one line on why it works in the USA
8	The ask	What you need signed off, the 12-month gates, and the one point of failure you are flagging honestly

9.4 An indicative deck is provided

`case_study_helper_info/99_Indicative-Submission_Deck.pptx` is a **market-neutral skeleton** of the eight slides above: the structure and the level of specificity expected, with placeholders where your answer goes. It contains no answers for any market.

The skeleton has no dedicated slide for the strategy pack in 9.2: put it on slide 8, or add one or two slides of your own. You have up to 10.

Use it to calibrate. Do not copy its wording, and do not worry about matching its layout: your deck comes out of Copilot Chat and will look different. You are judged on whether the deck sells the decision, not on how polished it is.
